



7 Drama: staging, dialogue and dramatic irony

Literary forms · IB Diploma · Concept guide and original exam-style practice

Understand the concept

Drama is written to be performed, so analysis must consider staging (set, lighting, movement, stage directions) alongside dialogue. Dialogue reveals character through word choice, rhythm, interruption, and subtext (what is implied but not stated). Dramatic irony occurs when the audience knows something a character does not, generating tension, sympathy, or dark humour depending on how it is used.

Worked example: follow the reasoning

Consider an invented stage direction: 'She smiles, though her hands do not stop moving the cup from one place to another.' A model analytical point: 'The contrast between the scripted smile and the restless, purposeless movement of the cup instructs actors to perform a visible gap between what the character shows and what she feels, so staging itself becomes a vehicle for dramatic irony if the audience has already learned what she is hiding.'

Quick check · multiple choice

Dramatic irony occurs when:

- A A character speaks in a heavily ironic or sarcastic tone
- B The audience possesses knowledge that a character on stage lacks
- C The playwright directly addresses the audience in a preface
- D Two characters argue on stage

Write your choice: _____

Structured practice

Answer in the space provided.

- 1 Analyse the following invented exchange for characterisation through dialogue and potential dramatic irony: HUSBAND: 'You look tired.' WIFE (not looking up): 'I slept fine.' HUSBAND: 'Good. I'd hate for you to be up worrying about nothing.' Discuss subtext, dialogue rhythm, and staging possibilities an actor or director might use. [20]

Final answer: _____



Answers and explanation

Question 1 [20]

- Point 1: the wife's clipped, deflecting answer ('I slept fine') combined with the stage direction 'not looking up' suggests avoidance, implying subtext contrary to her stated words.
- Point 2: the husband's line 'I'd hate for you to be up worrying about nothing' is ambiguous — it could be genuine concern or a pointed, knowing remark, and this ambiguity could be resolved differently by different directorial choices (tone, pacing, eye contact).
- Point 3: if the audience has earlier learned the wife does have something to worry about, the husband's 'nothing' becomes dramatically ironic, creating tension between the couple's surface politeness and unspoken conflict.
- Point 4: short, alternating lines (fast dialogue rhythm) create a clipped, tense exchange rather than expansive discussion, itself suggesting unspoken strain.
- Conclusion: argue that the passage's meaning depends heavily on performance choices, underscoring drama's dual identity as written text and staged event.

Quick check answer

B. Dramatic irony depends on a gap between audience knowledge and character knowledge, not on tone of voice or direct address.

Self-assessment

Compare each credited step with your own answer. Fix the first reasoning or content error, then retry the practice question without looking at the solution.

Based on the IB English A: Literature guide (2019).

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